

THE FIELD GUIDE · NO. 02

The Checkride

Oral Playbook

How to answer like a pilot, not a flashcard. The thinking, the structure, and a full worked mock oral — so you walk into the practical test ready to explain, not just recognise.

THE THING NOBODY PREPARES YOU FOR

The oral isn't a quiz. It's a conversation about judgement.

The written test asks you to *recognise* the right answer out of three. The oral asks you to *explain* it, and then apply it to a real flight — out loud, under mild pressure, with no multiple choice to lean on. That gap is where well-prepared students still stumble.

The good news: the examiner isn't trying to trick you, and they're not looking for a memory champion. They're checking one thing — **can this person make safe decisions as pilot in command?** Everything in the oral is in service of that question. Once you understand that, the whole exam gets simpler, because you stop chasing trivia and start demonstrating judgement.

THE STRUCTURE

What's actually happening across the table

The oral is built on the **Airman Certification Standards (ACS)** — the FAA's published blueprint for the test. For each topic, the ACS spells out three things the examiner must assess, and knowing this trio is half the battle:

Knowledge

Do you understand the concept? Not “recite the reg” — explain how it works and why it exists.

Risk Mgmt

Can you spot the hazard and manage it? This is the part that fails people who only memorised facts.

Skills

Can you do it — calculate the weight & balance, plot the course, read the chart? Some skills are shown on the ground in the oral, the rest in the air.

Modern orals are **scenario-based**. Rather than firing isolated questions, the examiner builds a flight — “you're taking two friends to an airport 80 miles away this afternoon” — and threads the topics through it: weather for that day, the airspace you'd cross, the weight of those passengers, what you'd do if the ceiling dropped. Your job is to think like the pilot of that flight.

★ WHAT PASSING LOOKS LIKE

You don't need a perfect score or instant recall. You need to be **safe, honest, and resourceful**: explain what you know, look up what you don't, and never make a decision that puts the flight at risk. A pilot who says “let me check the POH” looks *better* than one who guesses.

Bring: your logbook and endorsements, photo ID, pilot & medical certificates, the aircraft's documents and current charts, and your completed cross-country plan. (Full day-of checklist on the last page.)

THE TECHNIQUE

The 7 rules of answering like a pilot

01 Answer the question asked — then stop.

Resist the urge to keep talking. Over-answering wanders into topics you're shaky on and hands the examiner new threads to pull. Make your point, then go quiet.

02 Use your resources out loud.

The FAR/AIM, the POH, the chart supplement, sectional legends — reaching for them is a *skill the ACS rewards*, not a confession of ignorance. Real pilots look things up. Narrate it: “I’d confirm that in the POH limitations section.”

03 “I don’t know, but I’d find it in ____” beats bluffing every time.

Nobody memorises everything. Knowing exactly where the answer lives shows competence. Bluffing shows the opposite — and examiners are very good at spotting it, then digging until it collapses.

04 Tie every answer back to safety.

When you finish a factual answer, add the “so what.” “The spread is narrow, so I’d watch for fog and have an out.” That single move turns knowledge into judgement — exactly what’s being assessed.

05 Define → Explain → Apply.

A complete answer has three beats: say what it is, say how it works, then apply it to today’s flight. “A temperature inversion is... it happens because... so on this morning’s flight I’d expect...”

06 Don’t hand the examiner rope.

Volunteering “I’ve never been totally sure about...” invites a deep dive into your weakest spot. Be honest when asked, but don’t go looking for trouble.

07 Be honest — a corrected mistake is fine, a bluff is fatal.

If you misspeak, catch it: “Actually, let me reconsider that.” Self-correction is a sign of a safe pilot. The unforgivable move is confidently asserting something wrong and defending it.

THE MINDSET IN ONE LINE

You’re not a student being tested. You’re a **pilot in command** talking another pilot through how you’d keep this flight safe. Adopt that posture and the answers follow.

THE REFERENCE VAULT

The mnemonics that carry the oral

Memorise these cold. They answer a huge share of the factual questions — and reciting one cleanly buys you credibility for the judgement questions that follow.

ARROW

DOCS ABOARD THE AIRCRAFT

- A** Airworthiness certificate
- R** Registration certificate
- R** Radio station licence (international ops)
- O** Operating limitations (POH, placards, markings)
- W** Weight & balance data

AVIATE

REQUIRED INSPECTIONS

- A** Annual — 12 cal. months
- V** VOR — 30 days (IFR only)
- I** 100-hour — if flown for hire
- A** Altimeter / pitot-static — 24 mo (IFR)
- T** Transponder — 24 cal. months
- E** ELT — 12 cal. months

IMSAFE

FIT TO FLY? (YOU)

- I** Illness
- M** Medication
- S** Stress
- A** Alcohol (8 hrs / 0.04% BAC)
- F** Fatigue
- E** Emotion / eating

PAVE

PREFLIGHT RISK CHECK

- P** Pilot — current, fit, qualified?
- A** Aircraft — airworthy, capable?
- V** enVironment — weather, terrain, night?
- E** External pressures — get-there-itis

ATOMATOFLAMESDAY VFR EQUIPMENT ·
91.205(B)

Airspeed · Tachometer · Oil pressure · Manifold pressure
· Altimeter · Temp gauge · Oil temp · Fuel gauge ·
Landing-gear position · Anticollision lights · Mag
compass · ELT · Seatbelts

FLAPS

ADD FOR NIGHT VFR · 91.205(C)

- F** Fuses (spare set)
- L** Landing light (if for hire)
- A** Anticollision lights
- P** Position lights (nav)
- S** Source of electrical power

THE REFERENCE VAULT • CONTINUED

The five hazardous attitudes & their antidotes

Examiners love these because they sit right at the heart of decision-making. Know the attitude, the thought behind it, and the antidote — verbatim.

Attitude	The thought	Antidote (say it back)
Anti-authority	"Don't tell me."	Follow the rules — they're usually right.
Impulsivity	"Do it quickly."	Not so fast. Think first.
Invulnerability	"It won't happen to me."	It could happen to me.
Macho	"I can do it."	Taking chances is foolish.
Resignation	"What's the use?"	I'm not helpless. I can make a difference.

The numbers worth memorising

Currency

Flight review: every 24 cal. months (§61.56)

Passengers: 3 takeoffs & landings / 90 days (§61.57)

Night pax: 3 full-stop landings / 90 days, at night

Fuel reserves

Day VFR: destination + 30 min (§91.151)

Night VFR: destination + 45 min

...at normal cruise consumption.

Alcohol

8 hours bottle-to-throttle (§91.17)

0.04% BAC limit — and never while impaired

Oxygen

§91.211

Unpress. 12,500–14,000 ft: crew, after 30 min

Above 14,000: crew at all times

Above 15,000: offered to every occupant

Pressurised >FL250: 10-min backup O₂ per occupant

>FL350: one pilot on mask (quick-don exception FL350–410)

>FL410: each pilot on a mask at all times

Reg numbers are given so you can verify each against the current FAR/AIM — and so you can *cite* them in the oral, which examiners notice.

THE QUESTIONS YOU'LL ACTUALLY GET

High-frequency questions — and how to handle them

For each: the question, what the examiner is *really* probing, and how to answer well.

DOCUMENTS & AIRWORTHINESS

Q “Is this aircraft legal to fly today?”**WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → DO YOU KNOW ARROW + INSPECTIONS + HOW TO CONFIRM THEM**

Walk it: documents aboard (ARROW), required inspections current (AV1ATE — point to the logbook entries), no outstanding airworthiness directives, and a preflight that found nothing wrong. Finish with the judgement line: “If any one of those is missing or expired, it’s a no-go.”

Q “The landing light is burned out. Can you still fly — day? night?”**WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → §91.213 INOPERATIVE-EQUIPMENT PROCESS**

Don't guess yes/no. Run the process: is it required by the type-certificate equipment list, by §91.205 for this operation, or by an AD? The landing light isn't required for day VFR (so: placard “inop,” deactivate, and go), but it *is* required at night if flying for hire. Showing the *process* matters more than the answer.

WEATHER & THE GO / NO-GO

Q “Here's today's weather. Are you going?”**WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → JUDGEMENT, PERSONAL MINIMUMS, AND AN “OUT”**

Read the products (you've got METARs/TAFs cold — see Field Guide No. 01), state your personal minimums, compare. Then the key move: even on a “go,” name your bailout — “if the ceiling drops below X before the halfway point, I divert to Y.” A decisive “no-go” with a clear reason is a *strong* answer, never a failure.

AIRSPACE

Q “What do you need to enter this airspace?”**WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → ENTRY & EQUIPMENT REQUIREMENTS, BY CLASS**

Identify the class from the chart, then state requirements: clearance and two-way comms for B/C/D, the equipment (Mode-C transponder & ADS-B Out where required), and the VFR weather minimums for that class (cite §91.155). If unsure of a boundary, read it off the sectional out loud — that's the skill being tested.

THE QUESTIONS YOU'LL ACTUALLY GET • CONTINUED

AEROMEDICAL

Q “You feel light-headed and tingly at altitude. What is it, and what do you do?”

WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → RECOGNISE HYPOXIA VS HYPERVENTILATION, AND ACT

Define both, note the symptoms overlap, then give the safe action: descend, use supplemental oxygen if available, and slow your breathing — and because you can't be sure which it is, treat for the more dangerous one. End on prevention via IMSAFE.

SYSTEMS & AERODYNAMICS

Q “Walk me through what happens when you move the throttle / why does the wing stall?”

WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → DO YOU UNDERSTAND YOUR MACHINE, NOT JUST OPERATE IT

Explain the chain simply and correctly (a stall is an exceedance of critical angle of attack — at *any* airspeed or attitude — not “going too slow”). Tie it to recognition and recovery. If you blank on a system detail, say where you'd confirm it: the POH systems section.

CROSS-COUNTRY & PERFORMANCE

Q “Show me your weight & balance and takeoff distance for today.”

WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → CAN YOU ACTUALLY DO THE MATHS, AND READ THE LIMITS

Have it done before you arrive. Show the calculation, confirm you're inside the envelope, and use the POH performance charts for the actual conditions — pressure altitude, temperature (density altitude), runway, wind. Add the margin: “book distance is X; I want at least a comfortable buffer on this runway.” **One hard rule the examiner wants to hear:** use *actual* weights — weigh your passengers and bags, never estimate. A number you guessed isn't a weight and balance; it's a hope.

REGULATIONS & CURRENCY

Q “Are *you* legal to take these two passengers up today?”

WHAT THEY'RE REALLY ASKING → YOUR CURRENCY, CERTIFICATE PRIVILEGES, MEDICAL

Run your own checklist out loud: certificate & medical valid, flight review within 24 months, three takeoffs/landings in the last 90 days (and night-current if applicable), and within the privileges/limitations of a private certificate (e.g. no carriage for compensation). Cite the regs where you can.

★ THE PATTERN ACROSS EVERY ANSWER

Notice the shape: **state the rule, show where it's written, then apply it to the flight on the table.** Master that rhythm and you can handle a question you've never seen before — which is the whole point.

WATCH THE TECHNIQUE IN ACTION

A worked mock oral

A realistic scenario-based exchange. Watch how the answers stay tight, reach for resources, and always land on safety.

EXAMINER

It's a clear afternoon. You're flying two friends from here to an airport about 80 miles north, then back before dark. Walk me through whether you're legal and ready to go.

YOU

Sure. First, am I legal: my certificate and medical are current, I've had a flight review in the last 24 months, and I've got three takeoffs and landings in the last 90 days, so I can carry passengers. Since we're back before dark, night currency isn't a factor today — though I'd confirm sunset time and build in margin.

→ Answered the question, ran the right checklist, stopped.

EXAMINER

Good. Is the aircraft legal?

YOU

Documents aboard — airworthiness, registration, operating limitations, weight and balance — that's ARROW. Inspections current: annual, transponder, ELT, and the 100-hour if this aircraft is flown for hire. I'd confirm those in the maintenance logs, and I've checked there are no open ADs.

EXAMINER

You mentioned weight and balance. With two friends and full fuel — are you within limits?

YOU

I ran it this morning. With both passengers, their bags, and full fuel we're about 40 pounds under max gross and the CG sits just forward of the aft limit — inside the envelope. Here's my sheet. If a passenger were heavier than estimated, I'd recompute before loading rather than assume.

→ Prepared, showed the work, added the safety margin.

A WORKED MOCK ORAL • CONTINUED

EXAMINER

Let's say at the halfway point you notice the ceiling lowering ahead and the visibility dropping. What goes through your mind?

YOU

My out comes first. I'd already briefed a divert plan, so I'm comparing what I see to my personal minimums. If conditions are trending toward them, I turn around or divert to my alternate while I still have good VFR behind me — I don't press on hoping it improves. Get-there-itis is the trap, and I've got passengers counting on me to be conservative.

→ Named the hazardous attitude, chose the conservative action, tied it to risk.

EXAMINER

What's the lowest cloud clearance you can legally have in the airspace you'd be in there?

YOU

That depends on the class and altitude — let me read it off the sectional and confirm against 91.155 rather than quote it from memory... we'd be in Class E below 10,000, so that's three miles visibility, 500 below, 1,000 above, 2,000 horizontal from clouds.

→ Reached for the resource *before* answering — exactly right.

EXAMINER

One more — what does the alternator do, and how would you know if it failed?

YOU

It charges the battery and powers the electrical system in flight. If it failed I'd see a discharge on the ammeter or a low-voltage light, and I'd run the POH checklist — shed non-essential electrical load to preserve the battery and land at a suitable airport. I'd want to confirm the exact load-shed sequence in the POH for this aircraft.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED

Every answer was short, honest, and resource-aware, and each one ended on a safe decision. The candidate never bluffed and twice said “let me confirm” — and that's precisely what earns a pass. **Rehearse out loud until this rhythm is second nature.**

REPS BUILD JUDGEMENT

More mock scenarios

Five more the way an examiner runs them. Cover the answer, read the prompt aloud, and talk your way through before you peek.

SCENARIO 01 • THE DAY RUNS LATE

EXAMINER

You're an hour from home and realise you'll now land about 20 minutes after sunset, with two passengers aboard. Talk me through it.

YOU

First, am I legal to land at night with passengers — that needs three takeoffs and landings to a full stop at night in the last 90 days. If I'm not night-current I can't carry them after dark, so I'd land before night and continue tomorrow. Next, the aircraft must be night-equipped — position lights, anticollision lights, a source of electrical power, spare fuses, and a landing light if for hire — that's FLAPS on top of the day gear. And my fuel reserve goes up to 45 minutes at night.

→ Currency, equipment, fuel — the three legal gates, in order.

EXAMINER

Say you're current and equipped. Anything else before you press on?

YOU

The human side. Night brings illusions — especially a black-hole approach over dark terrain — so I'd fly a stabilised, instrument-backed approach and confirm my destination actually has runway lighting. I'd check NOTAMs, make sure I'm rested rather than pushing tired, and keep a well-lit alternate in my back pocket. Legal is the floor; I'd still hold my personal minimums.

→ Moved from legality to risk and judgement — the ACS structure exactly.

SCENARIO 02 • THE RUNWAY'S DARK

EXAMINER

You arrive overhead at night and the runway lights are off. Now what?

YOU

Many non-towered fields have pilot-controlled lighting — I'd key the CTAF to bring them up: usually seven clicks for high intensity, five for medium, three for low, within a few seconds. If there's no PCL or they won't light, that runway is unusable to me at night — I won't land somewhere I can't see. I'd divert to a lit or towered field using my landing light, and I'd have checked NOTAMs beforehand so a lighting outage wasn't a surprise.

→ Knew the PCL click sequence, had an out, checks NOTAMs in advance.

MORE MOCK SCENARIOS • CONTINUED

SCENARIO 03 • INSTRUMENTS LYING TO YOU

EXAMINER

In cruise, your attitude indicator and heading indicator slowly start to sag and drift. What's happened, and what do you do?

YOU

In a typical steam-gauge trainer the attitude indicator and heading indicator are vacuum-driven, so if they fail together the likely culprit is the vacuum pump or system — I'd confirm on the suction gauge. The good news is the electric instruments survive: the turn coordinator, plus airspeed, altimeter and vertical speed, and the magnetic compass. So I fly partial panel on those. In good visual conditions I'd fly visually and land at the nearest suitable airport. In cloud, it's an emergency — I'd tell ATC, ask for vectors, and work toward visual conditions.

→ Identified the common-source failure, knew which instruments live, flew the aircraft first.

SCENARIO 04 • A ROUGH-RUNNING ENGINE

EXAMINER

Cruising on a cool, damp morning the engine starts running rough and losing RPM. First thoughts?

YOU

Cool and damp is prime carburettor-icing weather, so carb heat goes on early — and I'd expect a brief extra roughness as the ice melts before it smooths out, which actually confirms it. Alongside that I run the basics: fullest fuel tank, mixture, check the magnetos. If it doesn't resolve I stop assuming and start preparing — pick a suitable field, set up for a precautionary landing, and I'm not shy about declaring if I need priority.

→ Matched the weather to the cause, knew the carb-heat behaviour, had a plan if it didn't fix it.

MORE MOCK SCENARIOS · CONTINUED

SCENARIO 05 · HOT, HIGH, AND HEAVY

EXAMINER

It's 35°C at a 5,000-foot-elevation strip and you're near gross weight. What's on your mind before you firewall it?

YOU

Density altitude. High elevation plus high temperature means thin air — the engine makes less power and the wing and prop bite less, so the aircraft behaves as if it's far higher than 5,000 feet. I'd compute takeoff distance and climb performance from the POH for the actual density altitude and check it honestly against the runway length and the obstacles off the end. I'd lean for best power per the POH on the runup, and if the numbers are marginal I'd shed weight, wait for cooler air, or not go. The aircraft doesn't care that the strip "usually" works.

→ Named density altitude, used the charts for actual conditions, brought real mitigations, not optimism.

★ HOW TO PRACTISE THESE

Don't just read them. Cover the answer, read the prompt aloud, and talk it through on your feet — ideally with your CFI playing examiner. The point isn't to memorise these exact words; it's to make the **define** → **explain** → **apply** → **stay safe** rhythm automatic, so a scenario you've never seen still gets handled like a pilot.

AVOID THESE

The six things that fail people

- ✗ **Bluffing instead of looking it up**
The single most common failure. A confident wrong answer, defended, ends the oral. “Let me check” never does.
- ✗ **Over-talking into a weak spot**
You answered the question two sentences ago, then kept going and opened a topic you don't know. Make the point and stop.
- ✗ **Weak weather judgement**
Reading a METAR isn't enough — the examiner wants a go/no-go decision with a reason and an out. Indecision reads as unsafe.
- ✗ **Fumbling inoperative-equipment logic**
“The light's out, can you fly?” trips people who memorised lists but not the §91.213 *process*. Learn the steps, not just the answers.
- ✗ **Weight & balance / performance errors**
An arithmetic slip or a misread chart suggests you'd do the same before a real flight. Do it beforehand, double-check, show your method.
- ✗ **Giving “macho” answers**
“I'd probably just push through” is the wrong instinct out loud. When in doubt, the safe, conservative choice is always the right answer in the oral.

△ IF YOU BLANK COMPLETELY

Don't panic or invent. Say what you *do* know, state where you'd find the rest, and take a breath. Composure under pressure is itself a quality of a safe pilot — and examiners are watching for it.

THE MORNING OF

Day-of checklist & mindset

BRING — YOU

- ☐ Photo ID
- ☐ Pilot & medical certificates
- ☐ Logbook with all required endorsements
- ☐ Knowledge-test results
- ☐ IACRA / application paperwork
- ☐ Examiner's fee, as arranged

BRING — THE AIRCRAFT & PLANNING

- ☐ Aircraft documents (ARROW) & logbooks
- ☐ POH / AFM
- ☐ Current sectional & chart supplement
- ☐ Completed cross-country plan + nav log
- ☐ Weight & balance, done for the day
- ☐ A current weather briefing

DO THE NIGHT BEFORE

- ☐ Sleep — fatigue degrades everything
- ☐ Re-read the ACS areas of operation
- ☐ Run one mock oral out loud
- ☐ Pre-plan the assigned cross-country
- ☐ Lay out every document

THE MINDSET

- ☐ You're a PIC, not a student on trial
- ☐ Slow down — think, then speak
- ☐ "Let me check" is a strength
- ☐ Conservative is correct
- ☐ A discontinuance isn't a failure

★ ONE LAST THING

The examiner was a nervous applicant once too. They want to issue the certificate — give them the safe, honest, resourceful pilot they're hoping to find, and the oral becomes a conversation between two aviators. You've done the work. Go show it.

YOU'RE READY FOR THE TABLE

Walk in able to explain it, not just recognise it.

You now have the structure, the technique, the reference vault, and a worked mock oral. Run it out loud a few times and the rhythm becomes yours — define, explain, apply, and always land on safety.

groundworkaviation.com

KEEP BUILDING WITH GROUNDWORK

- **Decode Any METAR & TAF** — the free weather field guide (start here)
- **Airspace, finally clear** — read any sectional with confidence
- **Performance & W&B without the panic** — density altitude, demystified

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